Ten financial actors control the future of the global food system

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Abstract

Up to 150 words. The abstract should be factual concise and accessible. Avoid references. State the problem the approach the main result and why it matters for food systems or policy.

In a world with over a billion people are overfed and 700 million people suffer from hunger, how companies produce food matters. Even more than that, knowing who owns our planet's food production machine matters. Here we ask, who owns the largest food producing companies? And how does this bode for the future of a sustainable food transition?

We take a very broad look into the food production apparatus: from tractor producers to fast food chains, through sugar refiner and supermarket chains. Our exclusion criteria is to focus only on large publicly traded companies with a market capititalisation over **XXXXXX NIKHIL, your number here :)**bn dollars.

(**?**) offer a literature of food ownership to try to see if family-owned firms versus investor-owned firms have different approaches to sustainable food. They find that family-firms sometimes lag behind environmental norms compared to corporate owned firms, but mainly because of

While this study helps contextualise what we do, we offer a more in depth analysis of food ownership. This has been done in other sectors, such as fossil fuel (**?**).

There is also growing literature questioning the risks and lack of competition associated with increasingly concentrated ownership in top-3 asset managers, mainly Blackrock, Vanguard and State Street (**??**)

Potential questions

- Does Blackrock/state street/Vanguard higher ownership correlate with better outcomes?
- How much of global junk food production is linked to Blackrock/State street/ Vanguard?
- How much of food emissions is linked to Blackrock/State street/ Vanguard?
- Role of Berkshire hatchway?
- Questions of corporate governance?
- Questions of corporate governance?
- linking accounts to deforestation?

Data

January 2009 to December 2025

OTHER VARIABLES

- Emission score Refinitiv
- junk food production globally
- food emissions
- company deforestation outcome? Spatial econometric? TARSE?
-

Results

Main empirical or analytical result

Describe the core finding. Refer to figures and tables where needed.

- Network?
- top x actors for food transition
-
-
-

Secondary result or robustness

Add additional results that strengthen the argument.

- can we have some calculation, econometrics or some complexity?
- dot plot showing percentage top 3 and harm? or all threes singled out and harm?
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-
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Discussion

Interpret the findings without subheadings. Explain implications for food systems policy or future research. Be explicit about limitations and scope.

Methods

Data

Describe data sources coverage and key variables.

Company Sampling

In order to extract data on equity ownership, we first identified a list of target companies across the entire Global Agri-Food System (GAFS). Sampling proceeded in four steps.

First, we defined the analytical boundaries of our study. Where many studies of the agri-food sector focus on one specific stage of the value chain we take a food systems approach (Cite) i.e. considering the system in its totality from food production to consumption. In order to achieve this, we first defined the GAFS as comprising three industrial stages -

(1) input production

(2) processing and product manufacturing

(3) distribution and retail

We then mapped this structure onto the categories of Global Industrial Classification System (GICS). The GICS is a hierarchical and exhaustive taxonomy of industrial activities designed by MSCI and SP which classifies individual companies according to their primary area of business activity. We identified 12 GICS codes which classified business activities in each of the three stages of the GAFS, mapped as follows:

(1) 15101030 - Fertilizers & Agricultural Chemicals 20106015 - Agricultural & Farm Machinery

(2) 30201010 - Brewers 30201020 - Distillers & Vintners 30201030 - Soft Drinks & Non-alcoholic Beverages 30202010 - Agricultural Products & Services 30202030 - Packaged Foods & Meats 30203010 - Tobacco

(3)

- 25301040 - Restaurants
- 30101020 - Food Distributors
- 30101030 - Food Retail
- 30101040 - Consumer Staples Merchandise Retail

All subsequent data was obtained from the LSEG Refinitiv Database.

In the second step, we identified all publicly listed companies in the GAFS on 2025-01-01 which corresponded to these 12 GICS codes. This sample comprised 3522 companies. Given our research interest in the large, public corporations which dominate the GAFS, we took as a subset from this sample all companies which have a market capitalization above 1.5 billion USD on the date of sampling. This resulted in a sample of 485 companies, representing approximately 90

In the third step, we defined the time period for analysis as 2009-01-01 to 2025-01-01. This period was chosen as it is a period in which there have been significant transformations in the ownership structure of major corporations in the world economy, resulting largely from the policy responses to the Global Financial Crisis of 2007-08. In the food systems literature, it has been noted that this period has been additionally distinguished by increasing financialization of the GAFS i.e. of the activities of companies being increasingly structured around the financial interests of shareholders, rather than social, health, or environmental objectives.

The fourth step of the sampling process was to account for changes in industrial organization i.e. mergers and acquisitions, bankruptcies, new firms entering the industry etc. in our sample. To do this, we reduced the sample further to include only companies which were listed for the entire 15 year period of analysis. This final sample comprised 287 companies.

Empirical strategy or analytical approach

Explain identification models or analytical steps clearly and transparently.

Robustness and sensitivity

Detail robustness checks and alternative specifications.

References

Appendix